

GAME CHANGERS

25 Women Athletes Who Broke
Every Barrier (Ages 8-14)

Daniel Tesfamariam

GAME CHANGERS

Author: Daniel Tesfamariam

Format: 8.5 x 11 inches | Kindle & Paperback

All rights reserved.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

1. Serena Williams - Tennis
2. Simone Biles - Gymnastics
3. Megan Rapinoe - Soccer
4. Billie Jean King - Tennis
5. Wilma Rudolph - Track & Field
6. Nadia Comaneci - Gymnastics
7. Mia Hamm - Soccer
8. Florence Griffith-Joyner - Track & Field
9. Venus Williams - Tennis
10. Ronda Rousey - MMA/Wrestling
11. Naomi Osaka - Tennis
12. Katie Ledecky - Swimming
13. Chloe Kim - Snowboarding
14. Aly Raisman - Gymnastics
15. Misty Copeland - Ballet
16. Diana Taurasi - Basketball
17. Alex Morgan - Soccer
18. Allyson Felix - Track & Field
19. Lindsey Vonn - Skiing
20. Sue Bird - Basketball
21. Danica Patrick - Auto Racing
22. Bethany Hamilton - Surfing
23. Jessica Ennis-Hill - Heptathlon
24. Claressa Shields - Boxing
25. Eileen Gu - Skiing/Freestyle

Athlete #1 | Tennis

SERENA WILLIAMS

23 Grand Slam singles titles

HER STORY

Started on cracked public courts in Compton, California at age 4. Her father coached her with no tennis background. She faced racism and body-shaming throughout her career but became the greatest tennis player of all time with her powerful serve and fierce determination.

HOW SHE CHANGED THE GAME

People called her too muscular, too aggressive, and questioned her femininity. She responded by winning everything and redefining what a champion looks like.

"I really think a champion is defined not by their wins but by how they can recover when they fall."

Serena Williams - Your Sports Challenge

YOUR CHALLENGE:

Practice one skill for 30 minutes today, no matter how basic it seems.

What I admire most about this athlete:

How she inspires my own athletic goals:

Serena Williams - Reflection

My sports/fitness goals inspired by this athlete:

Athlete #2 | Gymnastics

SIMONE BILES

32 Olympic and World Championship medals

HER STORY

Entered foster care as a young child and was adopted by her grandparents.

Discovered gymnastics on a daycare field trip. Has four gymnastics moves named after her and is widely considered the greatest gymnast in history.

HOW SHE CHANGED THE GAME

Faced pressure to perform despite mental health struggles. At the 2020 Olympics, she prioritized her wellbeing over medals, showing true strength means knowing your limits.

"I am not the next Usain Bolt or Michael Phelps. I am the first Simone Biles."

Simone Biles - Your Sports Challenge

YOUR CHALLENGE:

Try a new physical challenge today. Celebrate attempting it regardless of outcome.

What I admire most about this athlete:

How she inspires my own athletic goals:

Simone Biles - Reflection

My sports/fitness goals inspired by this athlete:

Athlete #3 | Soccer

MEGAN RAPINOE

2x World Cup Champion

HER STORY

Led the US Women's National Team while fighting for equal pay. She was vocal about social justice, LGBTQ+ rights, and gender equality, using her platform to demand change both on and off the field.

HOW SHE CHANGED THE GAME

Faced backlash for kneeling during the national anthem and for demanding equal pay. She never backed down, eventually winning the equal pay lawsuit.

"We need to be better. We have to love more and hate less."

Megan Rapinoe - Your Sports Challenge

YOUR CHALLENGE:

Stand up for something you believe in today, even in a small way.

What I admire most about this athlete:

How she inspires my own athletic goals:

Megan Rapinoe - Reflection

My sports/fitness goals inspired by this athlete:

Athlete #4 | Tennis

BILLIE JEAN KING

39 Grand Slam titles

HER STORY

Won the famous Battle of the Sexes match against Bobby Riggs in 1973, watched by 90 million people. She fought tirelessly for equal prize money in tennis and founded the Women's Sports Foundation.

HOW SHE CHANGED THE GAME

In 1973, female athletes earned a fraction of what men earned. Billie Jean proved women's sports deserved equal respect and compensation.

"Champions keep playing until they get it right."

Billie Jean King - Your Sports Challenge

YOUR CHALLENGE:

Learn about the history of women's fight for equal pay in your favorite sport.

What I admire most about this athlete:

How she inspires my own athletic goals:

Billie Jean King - Reflection

My sports/fitness goals inspired by this athlete:

Athlete #5 | Track & Field

WILMA RUDOLPH

3 Olympic Gold Medals (1960)

HER STORY

Had polio as a child and wore a leg brace until age 12. Doctors said she would never walk normally. She became the fastest woman in the world, winning three gold medals at the 1960 Rome Olympics.

HOW SHE CHANGED THE GAME

Overcame childhood polio, poverty, and racial segregation in the American South to become an Olympic champion.

"Never underestimate the power of dreams and the influence of the human spirit."

Wilma Rudolph - Your Sports Challenge

YOUR CHALLENGE:

If you face a physical challenge, work around it. What CAN your body do?

What I admire most about this athlete:

How she inspires my own athletic goals:

Wilma Rudolph - Reflection

My sports/fitness goals inspired by this athlete:

Athlete #6 | Gymnastics

NADIA COMANECI

First perfect 10 in Olympic history

HER STORY

At the 1976 Montreal Olympics, 14-year-old Nadia scored the first perfect 10 ever in Olympic gymnastics. The scoreboard could not display it because nobody imagined a perfect score was possible.

HOW SHE CHANGED THE GAME

Growing up in communist Romania with limited resources, she trained in basic facilities yet achieved perfection on the world stage.

"I do not run away from a challenge because I am afraid. I run toward it."

Nadia Comaneci - Your Sports Challenge

YOUR CHALLENGE:

Set a personal standard of excellence in one activity today. Aim for YOUR best.

What I admire most about this athlete:

How she inspires my own athletic goals:

Nadia Comaneci - Reflection

My sports/fitness goals inspired by this athlete:

Athlete #7 | Soccer

MIA HAMM

2x Olympic Gold, 2x World Cup

HER STORY

Scored 158 international goals, a record that stood for years. She transformed women's soccer in America and proved that women's sports could draw massive audiences and inspire millions.

HOW SHE CHANGED THE GAME

Played in an era when women's soccer received almost no media coverage or funding. She built the sport's popularity through sheer excellence.

"I am building a fire, and every day I train I add more fuel."

Mia Hamm - Your Sports Challenge

YOUR CHALLENGE:

Practice your sport or activity with the intensity of someone building a legacy.

What I admire most about this athlete:

How she inspires my own athletic goals:

Mia Hamm - Reflection

My sports/fitness goals inspired by this athlete:

Athlete #8 | Track & Field

FLORENCE GRIFFITH-JOYNER

3 Olympic Golds, world record holder

HER STORY

Set the 100m and 200m world records in 1988 that STILL stand today. Known as Flo-Jo, she was as famous for her style (one-legged racing suits, long decorated nails) as for her speed.

HOW SHE CHANGED THE GAME

People tried to attribute her success to drugs (she was never found to use them). She proved you can be feminine and fierce simultaneously.

"When anyone tells me I can not do something, I am just not listening anymore."

Florence Griffith-Joyner - Your Sports Challenge

YOUR CHALLENGE:

Express your personal style boldly today while pursuing excellence.

What I admire most about this athlete:

How she inspires my own athletic goals:

Florence Griffith-Joyner - Reflection

My sports/fitness goals inspired by this athlete:

Athlete #9 | Tennis

VENUS WILLIAMS

7 Grand Slam singles titles

HER STORY

Along with sister Serena, she transformed tennis from a country club sport to one of athletic power and Black excellence. She fought for equal prize money at Wimbledon and won that battle in 2007.

HOW SHE CHANGED THE GAME

Faced racism from crowds, media, and opponents throughout her career. Continued to compete at the highest level for over two decades.

"I do not focus on what I am up against. I focus on my goals."

Venus Williams - Your Sports Challenge

YOUR CHALLENGE:

Set a goal that others might say is too ambitious. Write it down. Start.

What I admire most about this athlete:

How she inspires my own athletic goals:

Venus Williams - Reflection

My sports/fitness goals inspired by this athlete:

Athlete #10 | MMA/Wrestling

RONDA ROUSEY

First UFC Women's Champion

HER STORY

Became the first American woman to earn an Olympic medal in judo, then became the first UFC Women's Bantamweight Champion. She proved that women could headline combat sports and draw massive audiences.

HOW SHE CHANGED THE GAME

Was told women's fighting was not marketable and should not exist. She made it the most watched division in UFC.

"I have this one term for people who are fake. I call them round people."

Ronda Rousey - Your Sports Challenge

YOUR CHALLENGE:

Do not let anyone tell you that your interest is not appropriate for your gender.

What I admire most about this athlete:

How she inspires my own athletic goals:

Ronda Rousey - Reflection

My sports/fitness goals inspired by this athlete:

Athlete #11 | Tennis

NAOMI OSAKA

4 Grand Slam titles

HER STORY

Became the first Asian player to be ranked number one. She opened conversations about athlete mental health by withdrawing from the French Open, prioritizing her wellbeing over competition.

HOW SHE CHANGED THE GAME

Faced criticism for protecting her mental health but started a global conversation about the pressure athletes face.

"It is okay to not be okay."

Naomi Osaka - Your Sports Challenge

YOUR CHALLENGE:

Check in with yourself today. How are you REALLY feeling?

What I admire most about this athlete:

How she inspires my own athletic goals:

Naomi Osaka - Reflection

My sports/fitness goals inspired by this athlete:

Athlete #12 | Swimming

KATIE LEDECKY

7 Olympic Gold Medals

HER STORY

Dominates distance freestyle swimming like no one before her. She often finishes entire body lengths ahead of competitors. She continued competing while earning her Stanford degree.

HOW SHE CHANGED THE GAME

In a sport obsessed with physical perfection, Katie wins through determination, work ethic, and love of the process.

"There are no shortcuts in life or swimming. You get what you put in."

Katie Ledecky - Your Sports Challenge

YOUR CHALLENGE:

Put in extra effort on something today. Five more minutes of practice.

What I admire most about this athlete:

How she inspires my own athletic goals:

Katie Ledecky - Reflection

My sports/fitness goals inspired by this athlete:

Athlete #13 | Snowboarding

CHLOE KIM

2x Olympic Gold (halfpipe)

HER STORY

Won her first Olympic gold at 17, then tweeted about wanting ice cream between runs. She brought joy and authenticity to a sport that takes itself very seriously, while being the most dominant athlete in it.

HOW SHE CHANGED THE GAME

As a Korean-American, she represents diversity in a predominantly white sport. She handles pressure with humor and grace.

"I just want to have fun and be the best that I can be."

Chloe Kim - Your Sports Challenge

YOUR CHALLENGE:

Approach your next challenge with joy rather than pressure.

What I admire most about this athlete:

How she inspires my own athletic goals:

Chloe Kim - Reflection

My sports/fitness goals inspired by this athlete:

Athlete #14 | Gymnastics

ALY RAISMAN

6 Olympic medals

HER STORY

Captain of the gold-medal US Olympic gymnastics teams in 2012 and 2016. Later became a powerful advocate for abuse survivors, speaking publicly about her experiences to protect future athletes.

HOW SHE CHANGED THE GAME

Used her platform to expose abuse in gymnastics and fight for systemic change to protect young athletes.

"I am not a victim. I am a survivor."

Aly Raisman - Your Sports Challenge

YOUR CHALLENGE:

If you see something wrong, speak up. Your voice can protect others.

What I admire most about this athlete:

How she inspires my own athletic goals:

Aly Raisman - Reflection

My sports/fitness goals inspired by this athlete:

Athlete #15 | Ballet

MISTY COPELAND

First Black principal dancer at ABT

HER STORY

Did not start ballet until age 13 (most start at 3-4). Was told her body was wrong for ballet. She became the first African American woman to be principal dancer at American Ballet Theatre in its 75-year history.

HOW SHE CHANGED THE GAME

Faced constant criticism about her body type, skin color, and late start. She transformed ballet's narrow definition of beauty.

"Anything is possible when you work hard and never give up."

Misty Copeland - Your Sports Challenge

YOUR CHALLENGE:

Start something new today regardless of whether it is the 'right' time.

What I admire most about this athlete:

How she inspires my own athletic goals:

Misty Copeland - Reflection

My sports/fitness goals inspired by this athlete:

Athlete #16 | Basketball

DIANA TAURASI

5 Olympic Golds, 3 WNBA titles

HER STORY

Considered the greatest women's basketball player of all time. She played professionally for over 20 years and scored more points than any player in WNBA history.

HOW SHE CHANGED THE GAME

Despite being the GOAT of women's basketball, she earns a fraction of what mediocre male players make. She advocates for pay equity.

"If you think you are done, you always have at least 40 percent left."

Diana Taurasi - Your Sports Challenge

YOUR CHALLENGE:

Push beyond what you think your limit is today.

What I admire most about this athlete:

How she inspires my own athletic goals:

Diana Taurasi - Reflection

My sports/fitness goals inspired by this athlete:

Athlete #17 | Soccer

ALEX MORGAN

Olympic Gold, World Cup Champion

HER STORY

Co-captain of the US Women's National Team and one of the faces of women's soccer worldwide. She balanced motherhood and elite competition, returning to play after having her daughter.

HOW SHE CHANGED THE GAME

Fought for equal pay while performing at the highest level and becoming a mother, proving women can have both.

"Be so good they cannot ignore you."

Alex Morgan - Your Sports Challenge

YOUR CHALLENGE:

Work on your weakest skill today. That is where growth happens.

What I admire most about this athlete:

How she inspires my own athletic goals:

Alex Morgan - Reflection

My sports/fitness goals inspired by this athlete:

Athlete #18 | Track & Field

ALLYSON FELIX

11 Olympic medals (most by any US track athlete)

HER STORY

Won more Olympic medals than any American track athlete, male or female. She advocated for better maternal protections for sponsored athletes after Nike cut her pay during pregnancy.

HOW SHE CHANGED THE GAME

Her fight against Nike's treatment of pregnant athletes changed industry policy and protected future athlete-mothers.

"My hustle is different. I know what I am fighting for."

Allyson Felix - Your Sports Challenge

YOUR CHALLENGE:

Advocate for a policy change that would help others, not just yourself.

What I admire most about this athlete:

How she inspires my own athletic goals:

Allyson Felix - Reflection

My sports/fitness goals inspired by this athlete:

Athlete #19 | Skiing

LINDSEY VONN

Olympic Gold, 82 World Cup wins

HER STORY

Won more World Cup races than any female skier in history. She pushed to compete against men, believing gender should not limit athletic potential.

HOW SHE CHANGED THE GAME

Suffered numerous injuries that would have ended most careers. She returned from each one to compete at the highest level.

"I was told that I would never be what I wanted to be. So I went out and showed them."

Lindsey Vonn - Your Sports Challenge

YOUR CHALLENGE:

Choose to be resilient today. What setback can you come back from?

What I admire most about this athlete:

How she inspires my own athletic goals:

Lindsey Vonn - Reflection

My sports/fitness goals inspired by this athlete:

Athlete #20 | Basketball

SUE BIRD

4 Olympic Golds, 4 WNBA titles

HER STORY

One of the greatest point guards in basketball history with one of the longest careers. She used her platform to advocate for social justice and LGBTQ+ visibility in sports.

HOW SHE CHANGED THE GAME

Played at the highest level for over 20 years while being openly gay, breaking barriers for LGBTQ+ athletes.

"Be who you are. It gives other people permission to do the same."

Sue Bird - Your Sports Challenge

YOUR CHALLENGE:

Be authentic today. Do not hide any part of who you are.

What I admire most about this athlete:

How she inspires my own athletic goals:

Sue Bird - Reflection

My sports/fitness goals inspired by this athlete:

Athlete #21 | Auto Racing

DANICA PATRICK

First woman to lead at Indy and Daytona

HER STORY

The most successful woman in the history of American open-wheel and stock car racing. She led the Indianapolis 500 and won an IndyCar Series race, breaking barriers in a male-dominated sport.

HOW SHE CHANGED THE GAME

Faced constant sexism and dismissal in motorsports. She earned respect through performance, not by asking for it.

"I am so driven. I wish I could bottle it up and sell it."

Danica Patrick - Your Sports Challenge

YOUR CHALLENGE:

Enter a space where you are the only girl. Own it. Belong there.

What I admire most about this athlete:

How she inspires my own athletic goals:

Danica Patrick - Reflection

My sports/fitness goals inspired by this athlete:

Athlete #22 | Surfing

BETHANY HAMILTON

Professional surfer after losing arm to shark

HER STORY

Lost her arm to a shark attack at age 13 and returned to professional surfing just one month later. She adapted her technique and continued to compete against two-armed surfers at the highest level.

HOW SHE CHANGED THE GAME

Rather than letting a life-altering injury define her, she redefined what was possible with determination and creativity.

"Courage does not mean you do not get afraid. It means you do not let fear stop you."

Bethany Hamilton - Your Sports Challenge

YOUR CHALLENGE:

Face one fear today. It does not have to be big. Just face it.

What I admire most about this athlete:

How she inspires my own athletic goals:

Bethany Hamilton - Reflection

My sports/fitness goals inspired by this athlete:

Athlete #23 | Heptathlon

JESSICA ENNIS-HILL

Olympic Gold, World Champion

HER STORY

Dominated the heptathlon (seven events in two days) and won Olympic gold at her home London Olympics in 2012. She returned to win World Championship gold after becoming a mother.

HOW SHE CHANGED THE GAME

Excelled at seven different athletic disciplines simultaneously while facing immense national pressure as the face of the home Olympics.

"Even if you are on the right track, you will get run over if you just sit there."

Jessica Ennis-Hill - Your Sports Challenge

YOUR CHALLENGE:

Try being good at multiple things. You do not have to choose just one.

What I admire most about this athlete:

How she inspires my own athletic goals:

Jessica Ennis-Hill - Reflection

My sports/fitness goals inspired by this athlete:

Athlete #24 | Boxing

CLARESSA SHIELDS

2x Olympic Gold, undisputed champion

HER STORY

First American boxer (male or female) to win consecutive Olympic gold medals. She became undisputed champion in three weight classes and is considered the greatest female boxer of all time.

HOW SHE CHANGED THE GAME

Grew up in Flint, Michigan amid poverty and violence. She used boxing as her way out and became the best in the world.

"I believe in myself more than you could ever doubt me."

Claressa Shields - Your Sports Challenge

YOUR CHALLENGE:

Believe in yourself more fiercely today than anyone doubts you.

What I admire most about this athlete:

How she inspires my own athletic goals:

Claressa Shields - Reflection

My sports/fitness goals inspired by this athlete:

Athlete #25 | Skiing/Freestyle

EILEEN GU

3 Olympic medals, youngest gold in freestyle

HER STORY

At 18, won gold in freeski big air with a trick she had never attempted in competition. She balances modeling, Stanford, and being the most dominant freestyle skier in the world.

HOW SHE CHANGED THE GAME

Represents a new generation of multi-talented athletes who refuse to be defined by a single identity or pursuit.

"Why not me? I do not think of limits."

Eileen Gu - Your Sports Challenge

YOUR CHALLENGE:

Ask yourself 'why not me?' about something you have been wanting to try.

What I admire most about this athlete:

How she inspires my own athletic goals:

Eileen Gu - Reflection

My sports/fitness goals inspired by this athlete:

GAME ON!

Play hard. Break barriers. Change the game.